Ink's ink, I suppose. He signed. I signed. Brooklyn scooted along behind our chairs, my mum not sure whether she ought to try to catch him. No chance of this all getting too serious, then.

Now we were standing again, a deal—and the writing—done. Senor Perez unwrapped his gift. He smiled:

'I'll keep this safe until we sign your next contract. Thank you.'

I smiled too. I'd heard almost the same choice of words once before: Alex Ferguson talking to a twelve-year-old United hopeful. Here I was now, 28 and England captain, excited and expectant and nervous all over again.

'You're welcome, Mr President. Thank you. Thanks to everyone. It's great to be here. I'm really happy.'

Happy wasn't the half of it. You can never know how the big moments are going to feel until you're in them. And it was only now I really understood just how significant this particular moment was.

Back at the Tryp Fenix, we were expected for dinner. It's the hotel where Real's players meet up before home games. They'd set up a private dining room downstairs. I'd joined Real Madrid: this evening was to celebrate that with the people who'd made the transfer happen. My management team, SFX, and a handful of people at the heart of Real's organization: our mate, José; Jorge Valdano; Pedro Lopez Jiminez, the President's right-hand man, and his son, Fabio; José Luis Del Valle, the President's legal advisor. And Victoria. Mrs Beckham looked unbelievably beautiful. Charmed the room, too. Made the blokes she was sitting with think she cared as much about soccer as they did. Who knows? Maybe, for just that one evening, she did.

It was a lovely couple of hours. I know how tense everybody in that room had been over the past month. This was the time for them to pop the top off a cold beer. No awkwardness, no politics, no pretensions: people who'd come to like and trust each other sitting down to a meal together. Even the formalities weren't very formal. My agent, Tony Stephens, got up to say a few words. A simple toast to great partnerships: me and Victoria and, now, me and Real Madrid. I thanked everybody for all the work they'd done:

'I've not dreamed about playing for many soccer clubs. There's not a player anywhere, though, who hasn't dreamed of playing for Real Madrid. Thank you all for making it come true for me.'